

Case Analysis Template

Current Situation

Step 1. The Facts

WHO is the decision maker?	Tim (Lead Project Manager) is responsible for assessing the ERP data and presenting the high-level solution. Senior leadership acts as the executive stakeholders as they set expectations and will influence final approval to the options selected.
WHAT is the task to be done (decision to make, problem to solve, opportunity to seize)?	The task is to determine how the ERP system should be corrected so that the data becomes reliable, structured, and properly governed. The problems to solve are non-normalized data, weak data structure, lack of standardization, and uncontrolled user access. This presents an opportunity to establish formal data management standards that improve long-term data quality and support better, and faster, decision making.
WHY has the issue arisen now? What is its significance to the organization?	The issue likely existed for some time but became more visible as ABC Company started to scale. As more employees interacted with the ERP system without controls, weaknesses (poor structure, duplicated data, and inconsistent table creation) became more difficult to manage. This is significant as unreliable ERP data affects reporting and decision making.
WHEN does the decision maker have to decide, resolve, act or dispose of the issue? What is the urgency to the situation?	Senior leadership is expecting results fast, and Tim is expected to submit a high-level plan within a month. Although a full ERP redesign will require significant more time, this period gives Tim enough time to assess major business objectives, identify limitations, and recommend a realistic direction for correcting the ERP environment. The urgency of the situation is significant as continued delays allow poor data practices increase the likelihood for organizational risk.

Step 2. In Depth Analysis

ABC Company's immediate business problem is correcting an ERP environment that has been structurally inconsistent and difficult to control because clear governance and data ownership were not established. The system contains non-standardized data, weak structural design, and unrestricted user access. This all contributed to excessive data growth and inconsistent data handling across the organization. These issues are

important because duplicate records and outdated information often require data to be combined, reviewed, and cleaned before it can be trusted to make real-time business decisions. According to Bernardo et al. (2024), organizations without strong data quality controls face greater difficulty producing reliable information for operational decisions. This slows decision making and contributes to unreliable reporting and dashboards. Additionally, unrestricted access increases organizational risk by allowing unauthorized changes, including data deletion. Exposure to sensitive information and potential compliance concerns are also potential problems for ABC Company, further increasing their exposure to risk.

The current IT environment contributes to the problem because the ERP system contains structural weaknesses that make data difficult to manage. Non-normalized data, weak table relationships, and inconsistent schema design have reduced the system's ability to maintain reliable connections across data elements. Technical controls also contribute to the problem. Unrestricted table creation, non-standard naming, and the absence of approval processes have allowed inconsistent practices to continue. At the same time, the existing ERP still provides value because it preserves historical business data, supports business processes already dependent on the system, and offers an existing infrastructure that can be strengthened rather than entirely replaced. From an organizational perspective, leadership did not prioritize governance early enough to establish clear ownership, stewardship roles, and approval controls, which allowed weak practices to also become routine. Luckily, senior leadership has recently shifted their focus and recognize the issues are big enough to bring in external consultants.

ABC Company reached its current situation through a combination of gradual neglect and organizational scaling. Poor data practices were allowed to continue over time, standards were not consistently enforced, and user access remained uncontrolled as the ERP environment expanded. As new employees began working with the organization, no formal training or clear governance expectations were established. This led to an increasingly more difficult structure to manage. Although the current structure may have once functioned within a smaller operational team, it became increasingly problematic as the business relied more heavily on timely and reliable data across multiple systems for decision making.

Ethically, accountability is a central concern because the current environment lacks responsibility for how the data is created, maintained, and protected. Data ownership should have been assigned to the organizational units closest to where data was created, because that is where the correctness of data can best be verified and accountability can be clearly established (Gils, 2020). Without clear data ownership, poor data practices can continue without clear correction, making it difficult to determine who is responsible for approving structural changes, enforcing standards, or addressing errors when they occur. Accountability also extends to leadership, since the absence of ownership and governance standards suggests the issues were allowed to develop without intervention. By not addressing these weaknesses early on, leadership contributed to the problematic environment. Additional ethical considerations are related to data privacy and compliance. Unrestricted access increases the probability that sensitive information could be viewed, altered, or mishandled by individuals without an appropriate business need. In an environment where employees are still new to data governance concepts, establishing accountability through defined ownership becomes important ensuring that data is managed responsibly and consistently across the organization.

Criteria

Criteria	Meaning/Measurement	Why Selected?
Data Integrity and Reliability	Measured by reduction of duplicate records, improved normalization, and greater consistency in reports and dashboards	Reliable data is necessary for accurate business decisions and restoring trust in the ERP system (Bernardo et al., 2024)
Governance and Access Control	Measured by defined ownership roles, approval processes, and reduced unrestricted user access	Structural improvements will not last unless clear controls and accountability are established (Mannino, 2022)
Implementation Feasibility and Speed	Measured by time required to begin improvements, cost impact, and ability to avoid major disruptions to business processes	Senior leadership requires a high-level plan quickly, so the solution must produce visible progress without disrupting operations

Analysis of Alternatives

What options are given in the case?

Are there additional options you think need to be considered?

Options		Performance Against Criteria		
		1: Data Integrity and Reliability	2 Governance and Access Control	3 Implementation Feasibility and Speed
	1 ABC brings a team of data experts in for a week workshop to discuss how to get the current system back on track and fix the data.	Moderate. External experts may quickly identify major data integrity issues such as duplicate records, weak normalization, and inconsistent structures. However, a one-week workshop would not provide enough time to fully	Low. While experts may recommend governance improvements, limited business familiarity may make it difficult to define realistic ownership roles, approval processes, and access controls that fit operations.	High. This option offers the fastest initial response, requires relatively low cost, and creates minimal disruption to current business processes.

		correct data reliability problems.		
	2 ABC scraps the entire system and starts over.	High. A clean slate creates the opportunity to rebuild the data environment with a fully controlled structure allowing normalization, cleaner table relationships, and stronger data standards from the beginning.	Moderate. A new system allows governance roles, ownership, and access controls designed intentionally. However, removing the current environment may also reduce visibility into which individuals currently work with the data within the systems. This creates risk that ownership and access decisions may not fully align with business needs (Mannino, 2022).	Low. This option requires high cost, significant time investment, possible loss of historical data, and major disruptions to business processes.
	3 ABC implements a phased hybrid approach that keeps the current ERP system while redesigning areas of risk, tightening user access, and introducing data governance standards over time.	Moderate-High. Although a phased approach may not identify every data integrity issue immediately, it allows more time than a short workshop. Duplicate records, normalization problems, and structural weaknesses can be filtered out over time. It also preserves useful data already in place.	High. Retaining the current system provides visibility into how data is already used across the business, making it easier to assign ownership, define controls, and introduce governance standards that align with operational needs.	Moderate-High. While full implementation can take the longest amount of time, improvements can begin in stages with limited disruption to business processes. Costs are lower than full replacement and can be distributed over time rather than requiring a large immediate investment.

Decision

Which option do you think is best? Why?

The phased hybrid approach is the strongest option because it provides the most balanced response across integrity, governance, and implementation feasibility. Strong data integrity and reliability are necessary because decision-making depends on consistent, accurate, and trusted information. This is particularly true when organizations rely on ERP systems for operational reporting and business insight (Bernardo et al., 2024). Unlike a short-term workshop, a phased approach allows ABC Company to begin correcting high-risk data structures, strengthening access controls, and improving reliability in stages that can be sustained over time. It also supports the gradual introduction of stronger governance, which is necessary because effective database environments require clear standards, ownership, and administrative controls to remain stable as systems evolve (Mannino, 2022). At the same time, unlike fully replacing the ERP system, this option preserves historical data. While implementation takes longer than a workshop or an immediate scrub, phased improvements make the solution more feasible as they allow changes to be introduced in phased cycles. This improves feasibility because it allows improvements to be introduced incrementally, which reduces operational disruption. This process gives the organization time to adjust processes, controls, and priorities in manageable stages (Valacich & George, 2020). In addition, costs can also be distributed over time rather than requiring a large immediate investment.

How does this proposed solution address the business problem identified in your analysis of the current situation?

This proposed solution directly addresses the core business problem by correcting the conditions that allowed poor data practices to develop over time. Because governance and ownership were identified as central weaknesses, a phased hybrid approach allows ABC Company to establish clearer accountability for how data is created, maintained, and approved while improving structural weaknesses within the ERP. High-risk tables and relationships can be prioritized for redesign, reducing duplicate records, inconsistent naming practices, and outdated information that currently weaken reporting reliability. At the same time, tightening user access reduces the risk of unauthorized changes or sensitive data exposure, while governance standards create a framework that helps prevent the same issues from reappearing as the organization continues to grow.

What are the ethical aspects to consider in regard to this decision?

Ethically, this decision requires clear accountability for both implementation and long-term oversight. As governance standards are introduced, data ownership must be assigned carefully so that individuals responsible for creating, maintaining, and approving data understand both their authority and responsibility (Mannino, 2022). This is important because poor ownership can allow inaccurate data, unauthorized changes, or inconsistent practices to continue without correction. Data privacy and compliance must also remain central during the transition, particularly as user access is reviewed and sensitive information is reassigned under tighter controls. Additionally, leadership carries ethical responsibility for ensuring that governance is not treated as a temporary effort, but as an ongoing organizational commitment so that the same poor habits are not allowed to develop again through gradual neglect.

Implementation

How will you go about implementing your decision (who will do what, when, and how)?

Short Term (30 days)	Medium Term (3-6 mths)	Long Term (6-12 mths)
Led by Tim, department leaders, and key system users, immediate implementation should begin with identifying data owners, restricting user access, and applying approval controls to stop additional poor-quality data from entering the ERP. Once ownership and access controls are established, high-risk tables should be prioritized for cleanup and normalization so that leadership can begin relying on more accurate reports for real-time decision making.	Medium-term efforts should focus on employee training and process adoption systems users. Staff must understand new data standards, approval expectations, and role responsibilities so that previous habits do not continue under the updated structure. Continued involvement from external consultants can support leadership in reinforcing governance expectations and improving organizational buy-in.	Long-term implementation led by governance groups and system administrators should focus on structural redesign of remaining data areas, formal governance review processes, and ongoing monitoring to ensure standards remain effective as the organization grows.

What are the major risks associated with your decision?

The major risks associated with this decision are primarily tied to how changes are implemented across access, data correction, employee behavior, and long-term system design. During early access control changes, there is risk that ownership may be assigned incorrectly or that employees could temporarily lose access to data needed for critical business activities. Data cleanup and normalization also carry technical risk because records could be unintentionally deleted, reformatted incorrectly, or interpreted inconsistently during correction efforts. This is especially true when existing values are unclear or naming conventions change across departments. Training introduces another major risk. Adoption depends heavily on employee willingness to change established habits. If users do not understand or accept new standards, resistance may weaken compliance and limit the effectiveness of the new process. User adoption is often one of the most significant challenges in systems change (Stair & Reynolds, 2018). Long-term structural redesign also creates risk because changes to table relationships, data flows, or governance controls may affect existing integrations and create unintended disruptions across systems that still depend on the current ERP environment.

What steps will you take to avoid or mitigate those risks?

To mitigate these risks, implementation should begin with a bottom-up approach supported by top-down leadership commitment. For ownership, access control, and early data cleanup, employees who already work closely with the data should help identify where critical dependencies exist before permissions are changed or records are corrected. This reduces the risk of assigning ownership incorrectly, removing necessary access, or unintentionally altering essential data because those closest to the process often understand where practical risks exist. At

the same time, leadership support remains necessary to formalize decisions and sustain governance efforts over time, since data stewardship is most effective when operational knowledge and executive support are combined (Gils, 2020). Training and change management should be used to reduce adoption risk. Because resistance often occurs when employees feel new controls interfere with established routines, change management should also include opportunities for employees to ask questions, raise concerns, and understand how the new process improves reporting reliability and protects business operations (Stair & Reynolds, 2018). This helps build buy-in and reduces the likelihood that users return to previous habits once formal oversight begins. For long-term structural redesign, risk can be reduced by testing changes in smaller controlled stages before full deployment so that integration problems are identified early without disrupting the broader ERP environment.

References

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